remains also show that the settlement had stood there for hundreds of years before the time of Ashoka.[18] As the prince moved across the central highlands, he will have noticed how starkly different his native land was from the mighty Ganga and its near monotonous alluvial plains, and from the Vindhyan rocks and the villages and towns that nestled so frequently at the foot of scarps or on isolated hills.

Not all the areas that fall on Ashoka's hypothetical travel itinerary have yielded ancient remains. Damoh and Sagar are among the areas where the ruins of early settlements have been remarkably elusive, while later mid-first millennium CE architectural remains and the coins of the Gupta dynasty are widespread.[19] Future exploration may yield an older or later past, but this sparsely inhabited stretch will almost certainly have felt Ashoka's footprints, or those of the animal on which he was mounted. Within a day or more after crossing Sagar, the prince's party will have encountered the fortified city of Airikina, which falls in the area of the present-day town of Eran. Located some 75 km from Sagar, Airikina is also about equidistant from Vidisha. It was built to ensure protection on three sides by a bend in the Bina river.[20] A mud rampart secured the unprotected side. The rampart was substantial, more than 45 metres wide and with a moat around it.

Ashoka could have halted here and partaken of the city's hospitality. Airikina possessed the means to provide him and his entourage the chance to recoup in somewhat more comfortable surroundings than the jungles of Sagar and Damoh. Shortly afterwards, he would have moved towards the part of Malwa on which stood the city of Vidisha. Lying about 250 km east of Ujjayini, Vidisha will have been Ashoka's last city stop before the last leg of his long expedition.

Its accessibility and distance from Pataliputra make Vidisha interesting on a journey's map. But more interesting are the romantic associations that it evokes, and these are central to any story of the life of Ashoka.